

Smooth Gradients

Building seamless value transitions

The ability to build a smooth, even gradient — from light to dark without visible jumps or streaks — is one of the most fundamental and demanding shading skills. It describes rounded, smooth surfaces like skin and glass.

KEY CONCEPTS

Layering

Build gradients in light layers. Start with a light even tone over the whole shaded area. Add a second pass over the darker portion. Add a third over the darkest area. Each pass overlaps slightly into the lighter zone, creating an even transition.

Even Pressure

Inconsistent pressure creates streaks and jumps. Practice applying absolutely even pressure across each stroke. Let the number of layers create the value variation, not the pressure. This is harder than it sounds.

Circular Motion

For very smooth gradients, use small, overlapping circular strokes rather than straight hatching. This breaks up the direction of the marks and blends better optically, even without a physical blending tool.

The 5-Step Test

To test your gradient control, draw a 5-step scale from white to black. Each step should be clearly distinct but transition smoothly to its neighbor. No visible stroke direction, no jumps, no stripes.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw a 10-step gradient scale. Each step must be even and smooth.
 2. Shade a sphere with a gradient from highlight to core shadow with no visible strokes.
 3. Draw a cylindrical form with a smooth gradient showing its roundness.
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FURTHER READING

■ Ctrl+Paint – Gradients

<https://www.ctrlpaint.com/videos/gradients>

■ Proko – Shading Techniques

<https://youtu.be/OcJPNMFFKHs>